This is not someone who is content with simply extrapolating on what he inherited. Instead, he has given foreign policy greater strategic clarity, stronger conceptual basis, heightened activity and better delivery. This was evident in the manner in which the immediate neighbourhood was approached and the extended one was engaged. It was also visible in the assessment of the global order and building stronger relationships with major power centres. There was then the planned cultivation of middle powers, of regions and sub-regions. This was paralleled by publicly upholding the interests of the Global South. The delivery of Indian projects there was radically improved, making them a visible symbol of a New India. First responder capabilities were effectively demonstrated, as was the ability to look after our citizens abroad when in distress. Fresh strategic concepts emerged, and so did new mechanisms and memberships.

The cumulative results were visible in India's higher global standing now. In other circumstances, it could well be called a transformational decade. But given the ambitious objectives set out, real changes have just begun. There is still a considerable road to traverse.

Nations and individuals come of age through demonstrations of strength. In the Ramayana, the relevant episode is the stringing of Shiva's bow by Rama when he goes to visit Janaka, the king of Mithila. This was a weapon of extraordinary capability that Shiva himself had given for safekeeping to Janaka's ancestor Devaratha, at a particular time when he could not trust himself to keep his emotions in check. Janaka had decided that he would allow only the person who could lift and string this bow to marry his daughter Sita. And it was this feat that not only ensured the marriage of Rama and Sita but announced the arrival of Rama into the world of warriors. This was immediately tested in a confrontation with Parasurama, a sage who obsessively fought the warrior community. Rama bested him by capturing and stringing Vishnu's bow made by Vishwakarma, the counterpart of Shiva's bow he had just strung, which had first come into the possession of Parasurama's grandfather. These were but the beginnings, and at every stage of his journey, Lord Rama overcame obstacles to realize his true potential.

Major tests do not come out of the blue. More often than not, they are preceded by earlier experiences of a significant nature. That is the natural evolution of people as it is of states. In Rama's case, this first happened when sages demanded his services to deal with demons that were ruining their sacrifices. Rama's father, Dasaratha, was naturally reluctant to expose him to such risks but finally consented with great hesitation. This attitude is also a systemic response in most countries when confronted with new threats.

In Rama's case, he first had to overcome the female demon Tataka in the Kamasrama forest. The next encounter in Siddhasrama was with more serious adversaries, the demons Maricha and Subahu. One was vanquished and the other reduced to ashes. Rama and Lakshmana then traversed the